A New Rafale Deal

INDIA'S PLAN TO ACQUIRE THE LATEST RAFALE FIGHTER JETS WOULD HELP BOLSTER ITS DEPLETED FIGHTER STRENGTH AND COUNTER THE GROWING AIR CAPABILITIES OF CHINA AND PAKISTAN

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SOARING AUTHORITY
A Rafale F4 fighter jet

At **A RECENT EVENT IN NEW DELHI, AIR CHIEF MARSHAL A.P. SINGH** pointed out that without a strong military, other instruments of national power, like economic heft, lose relevance. The Indian Air Force (IAF) chief was hinting at the 'elephant in the room'—the alarming decline in IAF fighter aircraft to 29 squadrons against a sanctioned strength of 42. With its main regional adversaries China and Pakistan modernising their fighter fleets, Indian deterrence is waning. Now, to remedy the situation, the Ministry of Defence is working on a proposal from the IAF to acquire 114 (mostly) 'Made in India' Rafale fighter jets under the Multi-role Fighter Aircraft (MRFA) procurement programme, to be built by the French firm Dassault Aviation in collaboration with Indian aerospace firms with some transfer of technology. Of the 114 aircraft, India plans to acquire 18 in a fly-away condition, or buy them off-the-shelf. The entire deal is estimated to cost Rs 3.25 lakh crores ($36 billion). The selection announcement could be made during French president Emmanuel Macron's February 19-20 visit to India. The IAF has 36 Rafales in its inventory, while the Indian Navy has ordered 26 aircraft carrier-compatible Rafale Marines.

Christopher Clary, a non-resident fellow at the Washington DC-based Stimson Center, says that while India has a qualitatively impressive air force, it "faces a quantitative disadvantage against Chinese airpower, and that disadvantage is growing. Rafale helps to stave off the trend".

However, a large deal like this takes time to fructify. The Defence Procurement Board, headed by the defence secretary, cleared the project on January 16. On February 12, the Defence Acquisition Council, chaired by defence minister Rajnath Singh, gave its nod to the MRFA programme, naming the Rafale in the Acceptance of Necessity. Now, the road is clear for negotiations on cost, technology transfer, indigenous content, delivery schedules and domestic partners. The agreement would then require political clearance from the Cabinet Committee on Security, chaired by PM Narendra Modi. Experts say even after an announcement, the final contract could take a year or more to be signed.

The actual delivery of aircraft is another matter. Given that Dassault has commitments to deliver Rafales to other foreign air forces, even the first of the 18 off-the-shelf aircraft would arrive only around 2032. The domestic assembly of the remaining 96 Rafales—depending on factors like setting up of assembly lines and production of indigenous content—would start yielding the first aircraft only around the same time.